



RPI's Outdoor Programs & Rensselaer Outing Club Rock Climbing Policies:

The intention of this document is to provide standardization of all indoor and outdoor climbing programs that are conducted by Outdoor Programs (OP) Rensselaer and Outing Club (ROC) at Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute. Climbing has the potential to be a dangerous activity. It is because of this inherent danger; the conduct of leaders and participants needs to be guided by accepted program standards. This document is designed to provide guidelines of conduct for rock climbing trip leaders which are accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

The standards put forth in the document are created with leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, Proper Documentation, and a Document Amendment History.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating a Rock Climbing trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor for unwarranted risk on the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
 - Leaderships are defined as:
 - Assistant Rock Climbing Leader (i.e Assistant Leader)
 - Rock Climbing Trip Leader (i.e. Trip Leader)

- Every rock climbing trip must have a Rock Climbing Leader and an Assistant Rock Climbing Leader as a minimum requirement.
- All Trip Leaders will always prioritize risk management during the program.
- Depending on the classification of difficulty of the trip, leadership is responsible for educating participants on important skills and pertinent information required to have a successful day.
- Leadership should take the time to seek adjustments for the needs of the participants.
- Trip Leaders should always act in a professional manner as a representative of the greater RPI and rock climbing community.

Risk Management:

- The sport of rock climbing contains elements of risk. Exposure to risk can be managed, but not eliminated from someone who engages in the sport of rock climbing.
- Location, weather, exposure, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, and more all contribute to potential risks on a climbing program.
- Many incidents/accidents are unforeseen and could be avoided with proper preparation. It is a major focus of a climbing instructor to anticipate these factors and provide protection from these risks to the best of their abilities.
- Proper documentation of accidents/incidents as well as post trip summaries (GRO reports) aid in the effort to anticipate possible unnecessary exposure to risk.

Etiquette:

- Proper etiquette is important to all who participate in rock climbing so that access to these places can be maintained and effects on the natural environment can be minimized.
- Trip Leaders should be aware of the rules and expectations adopted by the climbers at the trip location. (i.e. rappelling/lowering, dogs, radios, extended projecting, etc.)
- Be aware of local laws and regulations before adding/removing hardware or fixed gear.
- Treat others with respect and dignity. Rock Climbing Leaders model respectable behavior in the hopes of promoting good habits for other climbers in their community.

Drugs and Alcohol Policy:

Those under the influence of a substance that alters their ability to follow directions or affects their independent decision making shall be removed from any ROC or OP climbing program. This includes but is not limited to drugs, alcohol, medication, etc.

General Program Guidelines:

- Trip leaders must abide by the guiding principles mentioned above.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding their intended activity.
- Helmet zones are to be established early and enforced by the program's participants.
- Participants should always remain under the supervision of trip leaders.
- No one should approach the edge of the cliff (10 feet) without the use of a tether or other appropriate protection.
- No climbing during severe weather conditions.
- Only sport climbing and top-roping climbing systems are allowed.
- Only leaders and assistant leaders may lead climb.
- Lead climbing may only be conducted as sport climbing. (no trad protection exclusively)
- No bouldering unless the trip is a designated bouldering trip.
- Anchor systems should be built to their strongest and simplest capacity.
- Anchor systems should not be comprised entirely of traditional climbing protection.
- No climbing at night.
- The maximum ratio from participants to leader is 6:2
- Rock Climbing trips need to be announced a week before they start.
- All other ROC and OP Policies are to be followed in addendum with Rock Climbing Policies.

Rock Climbing Trip Leader Qualifications:

Assistant Leader:

An Assistant Leader is an individual that has a developed understanding of essential rock climbing skills. They are learning the role of Rock Climbing Leader, but at the moment do not have enough experience or knowledge to lead a trip. An Assistant Leader helps the Trip Leader in all trips leading responsibilities as well as takes the time to further develop their knowledge base.

To become an Assistant Leader for rock climbing programs, one must have:

- Participated in the ROC & OP Rock Climbing Curriculum course (or equivalent)
- Outdoor Wilderness Leadership Course
- Wilderness First Aid certification
- CPR Certification
- The ability to climb 5.8 outdoors.
- Can top-rope and lead belay using a tubular belay device.
- An understanding of OP and ROC General and Rock Climbing Policies.

Trip Leader:

A Rock Climbing Trip Leader assumes the role of lead instructor of the climbing program. They are responsible for creating the appropriate atmosphere, managing risk, providing instruction/details, and organizing the climbing trip. It is important that the person in this role is well tailored to the responsibilities they have.

To become a Rock Climbing Trip Leader, one must have:

- All the qualifications required for an Assistant Leader
- Passed the ROC & OP Rock Climbing Curriculum written and practical assessments.
- Approval by the current ECOMM
- Demonstrated higher level knowledge of rock climbing concepts and practices.
- Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Climbing Programs.
 - Rock Climbing Trip Leaders need to have been a prior participant or assistant leader at a specific location before they can assume the role of a Rock Climbing Trip leader for that specific trip.

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

These trips are designed to introduce climbers to the sport of climbing. Time is spent teaching basic skills and climbing knowledge. Topics that are normally covered are knot tying, belaying, climbing technique, leave-no-trace, etc. Approaches should be kept short (under 15 min hike) and the chosen climbs would be appropriate for beginner climbers. The base of the cliff should have ample space for all climbers and be devoid of any possible

obstructions. An appropriate range of climbing difficulties should be around 5.2 through 5.8.

Intermediate:

Trips in this designation contain characteristics that would not be appropriate for a beginner climber. There is less focus on teaching lessons and participants should come with developed climbing skills and knowledge. Considerations that would make an Intermediate climbing trip would be, but not limited to; longer approaches, limited space at the cliff base, need to clean anchors, higher average available climbing difficulty (5.8-5.12~) etc.

Advanced:

Advanced Climbing Trips are reserved for the highest level of permitted trip allowed by this document. Special attention needs to be given to the details of an Advanced trip before it is permitted to depart. A description of an Advanced trip would include elements of long/exposed approaches, need for additional skills/knowledge (rappelling, short roping, transferring fall-arrest/belay systems), exposure to harsh weather elements, long periods of 3rd & 4th class terrain, etc. Only participants with extensive experience in rock climbing should participate in an Advanced trip.

Packing Lists for Leaders:

Personal gear is the responsibility of the individual who is participating in the rock climbing program. If they need to borrow gear from the pit, it is up to them to acquire the gear according to Pit policies. Group gear will be the responsibility of the trip's leadership and will be borrowed under their names.

Personal/Individual Packing Lists:

- Helmet
- Harness
- Climbing Shoes
- Closed-Toed Shoes
- Weather Appropriate Clothing
- Water/Food/Snacks
- Appropriately Sized Pack
- Sunscreen & Bug Spray
- Personal Items: camera, medications, sunglasses, etc.

Group Gear:

- Chalk Bags
- Belay Devices
- First-Aid Kits
- Slings/Runners
- Climbing/Static Ropes
- Cordelettes
- Locking Carabiners + Hardware
- Quickdraws
- Prussic Loops/ Autoblock
- Guidebook/Route finder
- Rope bag/ground tarp (if needed)
- Copy of the Trip Sheet
- Permits/waivers (if needed)

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

All trips that leave campus need to have in place specific documents to run correctly. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and organization. In not doing so, the leaders of those trips open themselves to become liable in the case of an incident/accident.

Permits:

It is unlawful for climbers to access certain lands, parks, or cliffs without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local agencies may require permits to conduct climbing on land that is under their jurisdiction. There is the chance that permission is required on multiple levels of these agencies and could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who are facilitating the climbing program to make sure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual who is involved in an ROC or OP climbing program needs to have a RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participant to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the foreseeable risks that are related to the activity and outline the anticipated conduct and expectations of participants. Make sure that they are filled out to completion and that if the climber is under 18 years of age, that they have a parent's signature as well.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any means, students are to fill out a Change/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit them to OP.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Sheet folder a week before the expected departure date. In the event of changes or cancellations/additions, an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, a member/members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

"It is not the Mountain we conquer but ourselves" - Sir Edmund Hillary